

**FEBRUARY 2026,
“INSIGHTS TO IMPACT”**

**TECHNOLOGY LANDSCAPE
& EMERGING TRENDS**

**CASE COMPETITIONS:
CHEER YOIRUR PEERS**

**FIRESIDE CHAT &
STUDENT OPINION PAGE**

UPCOMING EVENTS

Specialty Masters Club

The Official Newsletter for SM students of University of Washington

Issue 03



The Tech Pulse: Signals from the Frontier

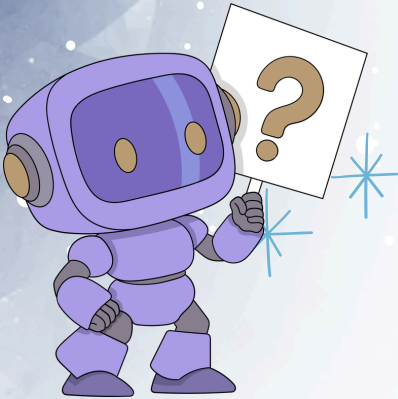
Big-tech & startups

[Wayve, an AI Driverless Car Start-Up in Europe, Raises \\$1.2 Billion \(4-minute read\)](#)

Wayve has raised \$1.2 billion in a deal that values the London-based autonomous vehicle software startup at \$8.6 billion. The funding, which could grow to \$1.5 billion if it hits certain performance targets, is one of the largest amounts raised by a European startup. Wayve expects to have its driverless taxis on the road for customers this year through a commercial trial with Uber. Consumer vehicles incorporating its technology will be available to buy by 2027.

[Anthropic's Pentagon Showdown Is About More Than AI Guardrails \(16-minute read\)](#)

Anthropic has the most constrained use age policy of all of the AI companies working on US military applications. It has a host of limitations on the use of its technology intended to prevent broader societal harm that includes core tenets such as 'Do Not Develop or Design Weapons' and 'Do Not Compromise Computer or Network Systems'. However, there are signs that the company's safety commitments are slipping. The Pentagon's threat to potentially remove Anthropic from the supply chain could be almost fatal to the business.



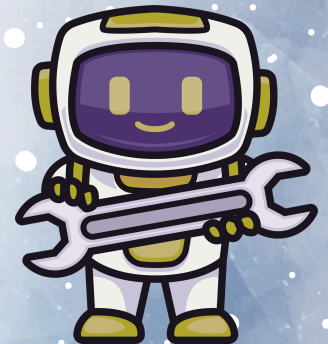
Programming, design & data science

[Meta and AMD Agree to AI Chips Deal Worth More Than \\$100 Billion \(4 minute read\)](#)

Meta has agreed to buy 6 gigawatts' worth of AI computing power from AMD in a deal valued at more than \$100 billion. AMD has agreed to give Meta warrants to buy up to 160 million AMD shares, roughly 10% of the company, for \$0.01 apiece, as long as certain milestones are met. Meta said last week that it would buy several million of Nvidia's GPUs as well, a deal expected to cost tens of billions of dollars. The company plans to deploy tens of gigawatts of data center computing power this decade, and hundreds of gigawatts or more over time.

[Apple's Next Big Thing Is a Push Into Visual Artificial Intelligence \(14 minute read\)](#)

The defining feature of Apple's push into wearable AI devices will be Visual Intelligence. Apple CEO Tim Cook has been dropping hints about AI wearables built around AI technology that can see the surrounding environment and use that context to take action. The company is working on its own visual models with the intention of making them central to its upcoming set of AI devices, which include advanced AirPods, smart glasses, and a pendant. Apple plans to hold its first product launches of the year in March.



Case Competitions: Cheer your Peers



Master's in Supply Chain

The Foster MSCM team earned the **1st Runners-Up** at the **2026 TCU Graduate Supply Chain Case Competition** (Neeley School of Business), working with Operation Smile to develop real, implementable solutions to expand access to cleft care. Under a 24-hour deadline, they balanced technical rigor with a deeply human perspective, proving that supply chain work, done right, can change lives. Keep reading to hear the story in their own words.

[Read More](#)

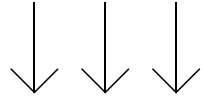


Master's in Business Analytics

The Foster MSBA team represented UW at the **Data4Good National Championship** at Johns Hopkins as **one of four regional champions** nationwide. They built a two-step AI system to detect hallucinations in educational content, not just a strong model, but a fully deployable, real-world solution. The experience reinforced a core belief: meaningful data work is about impact, not just methodology. Keep reading to hear the story in their own words.

[Read More](#)

FIRESIDE CHATS



FEBURARY 19TH



Product Management

The first-ever fireside chat was on Product Management — the highest requested topic from students. We also had the privilege of Jenne Pierce, Director of the UW Product Management Center, moderating the session. Driven by student-submitted questions, the conversation was candid and practical, covering everything from breaking into PM roles to working cross-functionally with engineering, design, and data teams.

Featured Speaker: Shiva Raj Kotini, Kayla Walker & William Wang



FEBURARY 25TH



Data Science

The Data Science fireside chat brought together leaders across product analytics, applied ML, and forecasting to discuss how careers in data science are evolving today. Moderated by Professor Hossein Ghasemkhani, the conversation was candid and future-focused, covering everything from AI's impact on the field to breaking into entry-level roles and growing as an individual contributor. With a house-full audience and the depth of student questions made it one of our most engaging discussions yet.

Featured Speaker: Pranav Sriram, Trevor Crosby, Shruti Pandey



NOTE FROM THE TEAM:

It's been close to a quarter since we officially kicked things off, and we wanted to take a moment to reflect on how far we've come.

Over the last one and a half months alone, we hosted 4 events: mock case calls, workshops, and fireside chats. A huge shoutout to Zuhaib and Vinayak from the Alumni team for bringing in some really fresh panels for the fire chats and creating a space where students could genuinely learn and take something useful away. Shoutout as well to the Comms team: Lou and Priyanka, for consistently backing us and helping amplify every event. The growing turnout each time, along with professors joining the firechats, speaks for itself.

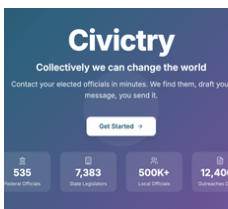
And of course, thank you to everyone who showed up and engaged with us so far. Excited for what the other teams have lined up for the upcoming quarter. Onto the next!

- Venkat on behalf of SMC

WHAT MSIS STUDENTS ARE BUILDING



Civictory: An AI-powered civic engagement platform



Civictory removes the friction between citizens and their elected officials by using an autonomous AI agent to identify representatives and draft personalized, policy-relevant outreach in seconds.

[Check it out](#)

- Amy Kitterman (First place, Gold cohort)



Orchid: An advanced AI plant care companion



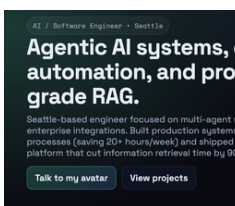
Orchid is an advanced AI plant care companion that uses generative UI (Pixel Canvas) with Live Voice Interaction to identify plants, diagnose issues, and deliver personalized care guidance in real time.

[Check it out](#)

- Masud Lewis (First place, Purple cohort)



Portfolio project: An AI conversational avatar



An AI-powered portfolio website that replaces static project pages with a conversational avatar, allowing recruiters to instantly ask about my work, strengths, and career goals—creating a faster, more engaging way to experience how I think and build.

[Check it out](#)

- Hardik Sharma



VinSight: An AI-powered Investment Associate



VinSight is an AI-powered Junior Analyst and Investment Associate that cuts through market noise using multi-model intelligence, deterministic risk controls, and autonomous monitoring to deliver high-conviction, proactive investment insights for retail investors.

[Check it out](#)

- Vinayak Malhotra

THINGS TO LOOK OUT FOR IN THE COMING WEEKS

The next couple of months/upcoming quarter is packed with opportunities ranging from skill-building workshops to fireside chats and mock interviews.



Workshop #2

Senior Manager (Principal) - Data Science,
Supply Chain - Amazon.



Mock Interview Panel

Get the chance to participate in
personalized 1:1 mock interview sessions.



Product Build: AI Factuality Detection

The tech team is excited to kick off product development in the
coming weeks (*pending final stakeholder conversations*).

We're building a solution to detect the factuality of AI-generated
text, classifying outputs based on correctness and reliability.

Version 0 was developed during the **Data4Good Analytics
Competition** earlier this month, and we're now exploring how to
productize it for more use cases at UW.



Interested in building with us?

Join us to gain hands-on experience in product management,
project management, vibe coding, and traditional ML.

Reach out at nattts@uw.edu or cyw323@uw.edu

Have questions?
Looking to be part of the team?
Reach out to us at:

 
email/smcommittee@uw.edu
uw-specialitymastersclub

Thank you!

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